has started will eventually end up in creating a huge middle class, but the middle class doesn't go from 200 to 500 million suddenly. It will progressively grow.'

BJP leaders see a clear distinction between their approach to social-welfare spending and that of the Congress. The difference, in their view, lies in targeting and higher efficiency. 'The Congress's way of public spending was statistical. They would say "I spent Rs 40,000 crore". Here, Narendra Modiji is saying something else. He is saying, "I helped 2.5 crore Indians get subsidised cylinders. Twenty-five crore Indians have got DBT." He is not talking about numbers. He is talking about the number of Indian citizens who are getting money into their bank accounts, who are getting subsidies,' Chandrasekhar said. 'He's targeting. The biggest difference between Congress and Narendra Modi was that if he is spending Rs 30,000 crore and they were spending Rs 30,000 crore, but God knows where their Rs 30,000 crore were going. But here, in our view, Rs 30,000 crore is the sum of the beneficiaries—the 2.5 crore who got cylinders and the 25 crore who got DBT and others. He's adding up the math and getting that Rs 30,000 crore used properly. If you do that for a full five-year period like this, and you back it up with grants, jobs, Mudra loans and so on, you are potentially lifting people out of poverty faster than we did in the last sixty years…. If the niyat, the effort, the capability and the execution remain at this level and the focus is unrelentingly on getting these 35-40 crore people out of poverty permanently, then boss, this is a juggernaut country.'[126]

Would it be fair, then, to say that the BJP is economically left-wing? A few months later, I put this question to the civil servant and former deputy chairperson of the Planning Commission, Montek Singh Ahluwalia. 'This right-left binary has become a little jaded,' he responded. 'I think you are implying that the BJP was expected to be more pro-private sector but it isn't. Part of the problem is because, in the words of Arvind Subramanian, the private sector is now "stigmatised". As Amartya Sen has said, India doesn't really have a genuine right-wing party in economic terms.'[127]

This is a view that many in Delhi's economic establishment, on both sides of the political divide, agree with. Says a senior former bureaucrat who has worked in a previous prime minister's office,